

87 Jehu

The furious charioteer who wiped out Ahab's house and Baal worship, but never gave God his whole heart.

Jehu was an army commander when a young prophet sent by Elisha anointed him king, to carry out God's judgment on the house of Ahab. He acted with frightening speed. In days he killed King Joram of Israel and King Ahaziah of Judah, had Jezebel thrown from a window, and saw to the deaths of Ahab's seventy sons. Then he trapped Baal's worshippers in one temple and destroyed them. God commended him. Yet Jehu kept Jeroboam's golden calves, and nearly a century later Hosea announced judgment for the bloodshed at Jezreel.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yehu</i> , probably "the LORD is he"
Family	Son of Jehoshaphat, son of Nimshi (2 Kings 9:2)
Before king	A captain of the army at Ramoth-gilead (2 Kings 9:5)
Reign	28 years in Samaria, c. 841–814 BC (2 Kings 10:36)
Key places	Ramoth-gilead, Jezreel, Samaria, the house of Baal
Key people	Elisha, Joram, Ahaziah, Jezebel, Jehonadab
Dynasty	Four generations after him on Israel's throne (2 Kings 10:30; 15:12)
New Testament	Not named

"But Jehu took no heed to walk in the law of the LORD God of Israel with all his heart: for he departed not from the sins of Jeroboam, which made Israel to sin."

2 Kings 10:31, KJV

The life of Jehu

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. 2 Kings 9–10 appears to cover only a few days or weeks.

Years before	●	Named by God At Horeb, God tells Elijah to anoint "Jehu the son of Nimshi" king over Israel. The task passes to Elisha's circle years later. <i>1 Kings 19:15–17</i>
c. 841 BC	●	Anointed at Ramoth-gilead A young prophet sent by Elisha takes Jehu into an inner room and pours oil on his head. He charges him to strike down the house of Ahab. The captains proclaim him king. <i>2 Kings 9:1–13</i>
Soon after	●	Kills two kings Jehu drives furiously to Jezreel. He shoots Joram of Israel through the heart and has his body thrown into Naboth's field. Ahaziah of Judah is wounded as he flees and dies at Megiddo. <i>2 Kings 9:14–29</i>
That day	●	Jezebel's death At Jezreel, Jezebel mocks him from a window. Jehu calls out, "Who is on my side? who?" Her servants throw her down, and Elijah's word about the dogs is fulfilled. <i>2 Kings 9:30–37</i>
The following days	●	Ends Ahab's line He writes to the leaders in Samaria, and they send him the heads of Ahab's seventy sons. He also kills Ahab's officials, Ahaziah's relatives and all who remain of Ahab's house. <i>2 Kings 10:1–17</i>
In Samaria	●	Destroys Baal worship Pretending to be a greater servant of Baal than Ahab, he gathers Baal's worshippers into their temple and has them killed. The temple is torn down. <i>2 Kings 10:18–28</i>
c. 841–814 BC	●	Reigns 28 years He keeps Jeroboam's golden calves at Bethel and Dan. God begins to cut Israel short, and Hazael of Syria takes all the land east of the Jordan. <i>2 Kings 10:29–36</i>

Key activities

God commends Jehu for carrying out his word against Ahab's house (2 Kings 10:30), yet Hosea later condemns "the blood of Jezreel" (Hosea 1:4). Readers differ on how to hold these together. Many think Jehu did what God commanded but went beyond it, or did it for his own ends.

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- 1 Accepted the call.** When his fellow officers asked why the prophet came, he told them, and they made him king on the spot. *2 Kings 9:11–13*
 - 2 Drove furiously.** The watchman knew him from a distance: "the driving is like the driving of Jehu the son of Nimshi; for he driveth furiously." *2 Kings 9:20*
 - 3 Fulfilled Elijah's word.** He had Joram's body cast into Naboth's field, recalling God's judgment for Naboth's blood. *2 Kings 9:24–26*
 - 4 Judged Jezebel.** He called for allies at the window, and she was thrown down. *2 Kings 9:32–37*
 - 5 Wiped out Ahab's house.** He left none of Ahab's family, great men or priests in Jezreel. *2 Kings 10:6–11*
 - 6 Boasted of his zeal.** He told Jehonadab, "Come with me, and see my zeal for the LORD." *2 Kings 10:15–16*
 - 7 Destroyed Baal worship.** He tricked the worshippers of Baal, killed them, and turned Baal's temple into a latrine. *2 Kings 10:18–28*
 - 8 Kept the calves.** He did not turn from the golden calves at Bethel and Dan. *2 Kings 10:29, 31*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jehu.

Old Testament

1 Kings 19:16–17	God names Jehu as the one who will judge
2 Kings 9–10	The main account of his rise and reign
2 Chronicles 22:7–9	God brought Ahaziah of Judah to Jehu
2 Kings 10:30; 15:12	Four generations on the throne, promised and kept
Hosea 1:4	God will avenge "the blood of Jezreel" on Jehu's house
Echo: Numbers 25:10–13	Phinehas praised for zeal against idolatry

New Testament

Echo: Romans 10:2	Some have "a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge"
Echo: Matthew 15:8	Honouring God with lips, the heart far away

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jehu remove from Israel, and what did he leave in place (2 Kings 10:28–31)?
2. *Understand:* How can Jehu be commended by God (2 Kings 10:30) and still be condemned in Hosea 1:4?
3. *Apply:* Jehu said, "see my zeal for the LORD." When is your zeal for God really zeal for being seen?
4. *Apply:* Jehu cleared out Baal but kept the calves. What is one "calf" you have kept, a habit or loyalty you have never given up to God?